Responding to microaggressions in class

Do I address microaggressions when they arise?

WHAT IS IT?

Microaggressions, whether from students or staff, are proactively addressed when they arise

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

Teaching is never neutral. Choices about readings, cases, examples, guest speakers, classroom norms and professional pathways tell students whose lives and knowledge are considered normal, legitimate or peripheral. When students cannot recognise themselves or their communities in the discipline, participation can start to feel risky or pointless.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “People like me do not seem to exist in this field.”
- “We only appear when the course is discussing disadvantage or a problem.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Prepare a simple response line so harmful comments do not go unaddressed.
- Separate the behaviour from the person while remaining clear about impact.
- Follow up when needed and connect students with support if a moment has landed badly.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

When a stereotyped remark is made in class, the educator names the issue, recentres the discussion and clarifies the standard for future participation.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

In this course, we aim to respond to microaggressions and exclusionary comments rather than leaving students to manage them alone. If the way a class or learning activity is organised makes it harder for you to participate…

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Inclusive practice

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